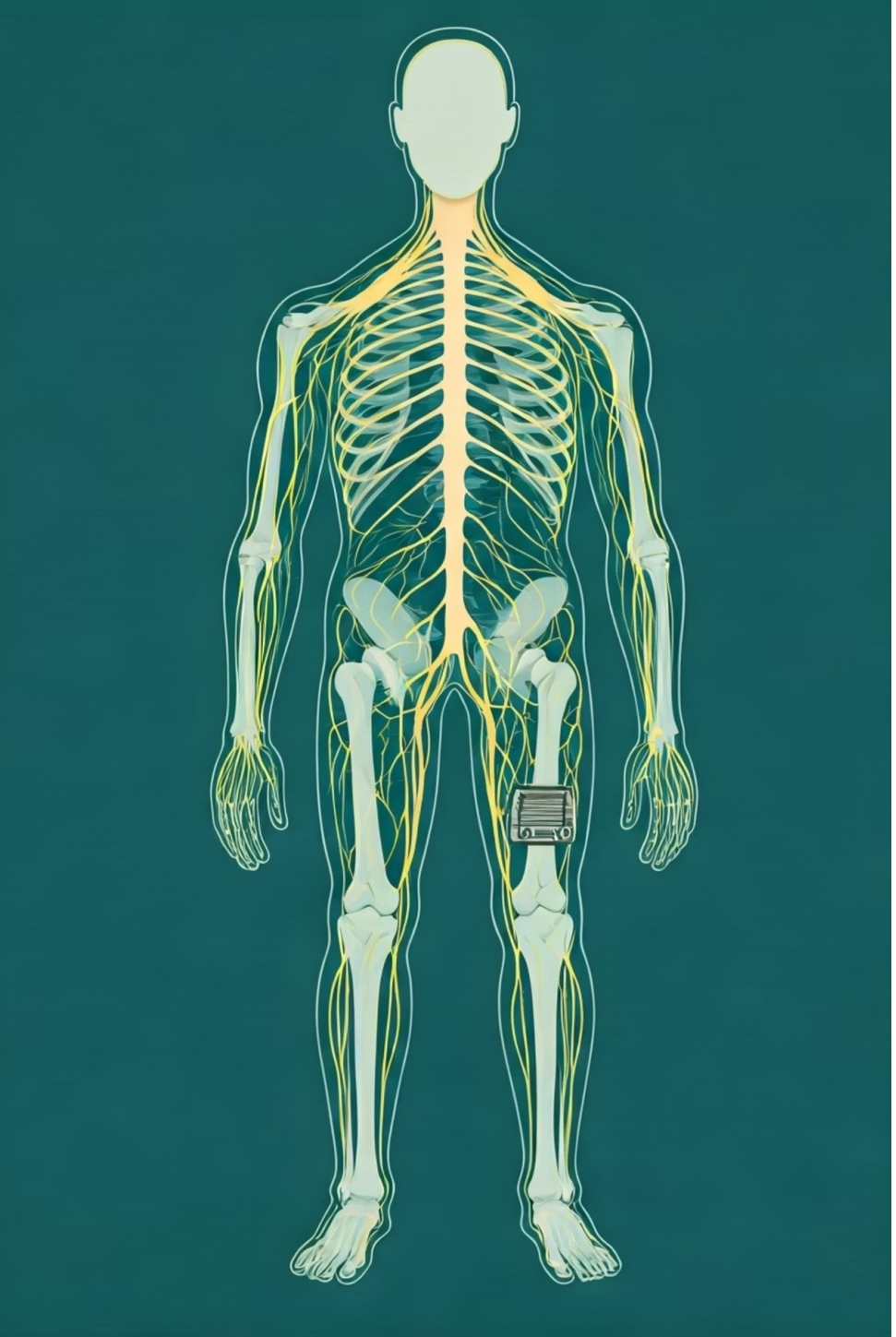


Your Nervous System: The Gas & The Brake

Anxiety is your body's alarm system. We'll explore two key parts: the gas pedal that revs you up and the brake pedal that cools you down.

Meet Your 'Gas Pedal'

Racing Heart

Pumps oxygen to muscles for fight/flight

Fast Breathing

Takes in more oxygen for blood

Tense Muscles

Ready for immediate action

Sweating

Prevents overheating during exertion

Meet Your 'Brake Pedal'

Slower Heartbeat

Heart rate normalizes

Deeper Breathing

Breathing slows, signaling safety

Relaxed Muscles

Tension released from body

Digestion Resumes

Body returns to normal functions

Finding Your Balance

Stressor

Work deadlines push gas pedal

Response

Nervous system reacts

Recovery

Apply brake with calming tools

Balance

Return to equilibrium

Gas Pedal Triggers

External Triggers

Work pressure, loud noises, crowded spaces

Internal Triggers

Worried thoughts, physical sensations, memories

Threshold Effects

Small stressors add up over time

Individual Sensitivity

Everyone's triggers are different

Applying Your Brake

Deep Breathing

Slow inhales, longer exhales activate brake

Physical Movement

Walking, stretching release tension

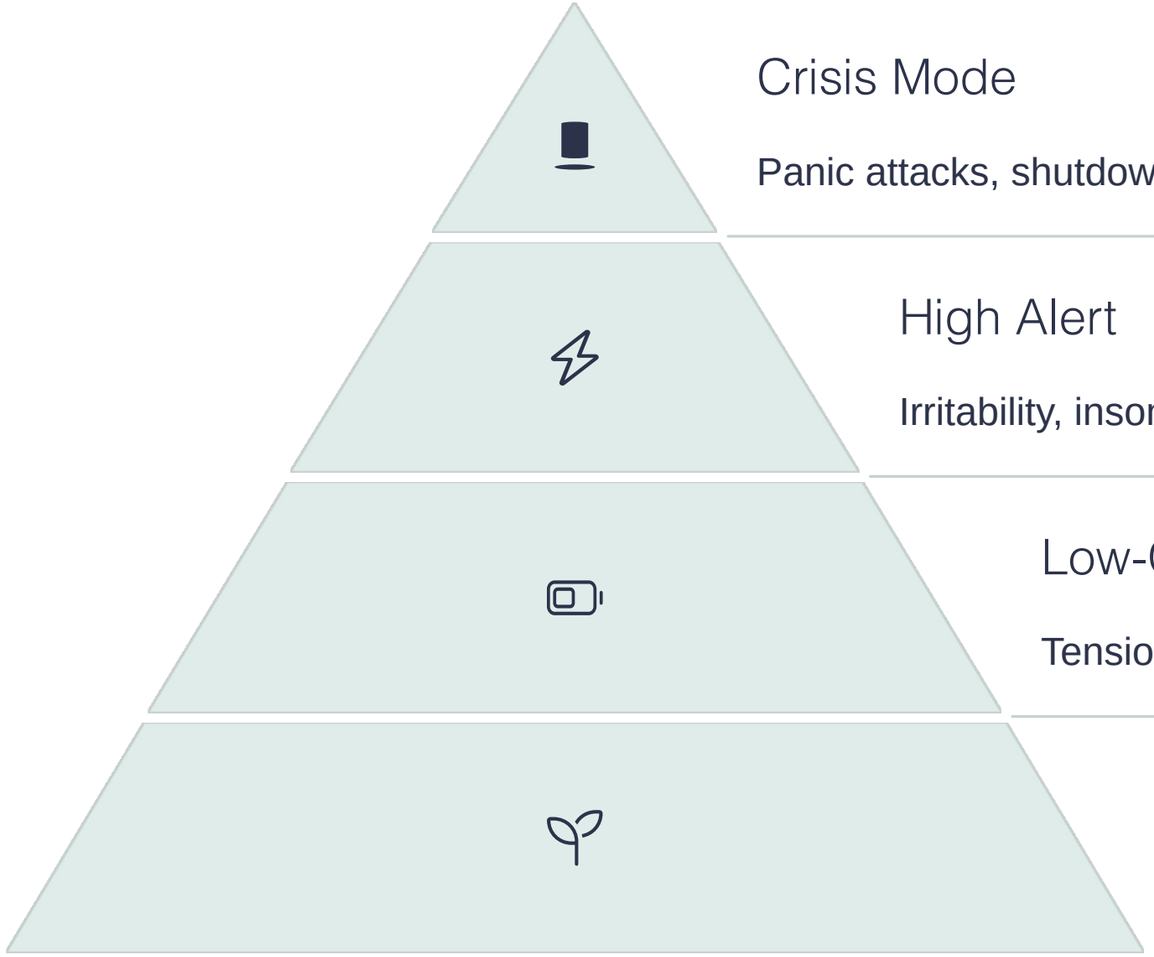
Sensory Grounding

Focus on five senses to return to present

Social Connection

Safe relationships regulate nervous system

Signs Your System Needs Balance



Crisis Mode

Panic attacks, shutdowns

High Alert

Irritability, insomnia, racing thoughts

Low-Grade Stress

Tension, fatigue, worry

Prevention Zone

Daily brake practice helps prevent escalation

You're Learning the Controls

Recognition

Identify when gas pedal activates

Response

Choose brake pedal techniques

Regulation

Practice strengthens brake power

Resilience

Balance comes more naturally over time